KING'S CAREER IS A TESTAMENT TO HIS TALENT, HARD WORK, LOVE FOR RISKS AND HIS INDIFFERENCE TO EXTERNAL VALIDATION

While the likes of Yo Yo Honey Singh, Badshah and Raftaar were infusing Punjabi hip-hop into desi pop culture, King paid close attention to the rise of gully rap in the bylanes of Mumbai, with Naezy and DIVINE leading the charge.

He dropped his first single as King Rocco in 2015, but it would be another four years before he tasted success. In 2019, he participated in MTV's hip-hop reality contest Hustle, and though he didn't win, the show brought him closer to his dream.

King's burgeoning career is a testament not just to his talent and hard work, but also to his indifference to external validation, and love for risks. "I can't live life wondering, 'What will people say?' If people don't like me as an actor, I'll not get any more offers and go back to being a musician," he says with a laugh.

Now that the show has dropped, King is itching to go back into the studio. "I haven't made music in almost six months, and that is very strange for me." He carries with him all the learnings from his acting debut. "My first reaction when my business manager told me about *Lukkhe* was that I wanted to learn a new art form. Acting has helped me understand my body and physicality so much more, and that's going to help make my stage performances better." ■

—Karishma Upadhyay

PLAY ▼

FOR THE LOVE OF THEATRE

WRITER, DIRECTOR AND ACTOR **MANAV KAUL**'S PLAY *TRAASADI*—ABOUT THE LOSS OF A MOTHER—IS HEADED TO SCANDINAVIA THIS MONTH

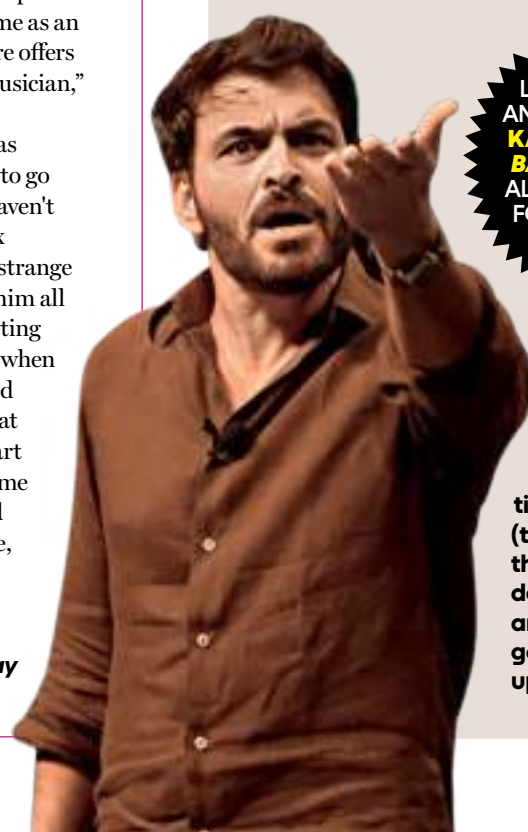
In 2022, when Manav Kaul was visiting Sweden, he was pleasantly surprised to find a community of Indians and Nepalis who were avid readers of his books. The actor, theatre director, playwright, filmmaker and author is now chuffed that his play *Traasadi* has also found its way to northern Europe.

The solo-performance, one-act play written, directed and enacted by Kaul deals with the loss of a mother. It has been staged more than 75 times in different cities in India since it opened one and a half years ago. Now, it will be staged in Stockholm (Sweden), Copenhagen (Denmark) and Oslo (Norway) at the end of May.

"Scandinavia has a fairly large community of Indians, Nepalis, Pakistanis and Bangladeshis who follow me on social media and are aware of my work. There is a group that organises stand-up comedies, and they reached out to me to perform this play. I reminded them of the play's title—*Traasadi* (tragedy)—and that it deals with death, but they are very keen to go beyond stand-up comedies and stage other genres that more people can connect with," he says, adding that he is looking forward to the audience's response. It is the first time that the play is touring internationally. Coincidentally, his other play, *Jo Dooba So Paar*, is also making its foreign debut, with shows in Germany this July. "It is a great boost to the kind of work our theatre group Aranya is doing," Kaul adds.

After Scandinavia, Kaul will also visit Iceland and Austria for his annual break, where he intends to spend time writing and relaxing. "There is a lot of writing I need to finish and also start," he says, adding that there is a new play in the pipeline that he has already finished, which will open once he returns from his break. ■

—Deepali Dhingra



LIKE *TRAASADI*, ANOTHER PLAY BY **KAUL—*JO DOOBA SO PAAR*—** IS ALSO MAKING ITS FOREIGN DEBUT IN JULY

Traasadi will be staged in Stockholm on May 29, Copenhagen on May 30 and Oslo on May 31